

ART NOUVEAU

International style of art and architecture

Art Nouveau is an international style of art, architecture and applied art, especially the decorative arts, that was most popular between 1890 and 1910. A reaction to the academic art of the 19th century, it was inspired by natural forms and structures, particularly the curved lines of plants and flowers. The style emerged in Brussels in the 1880s and quickly spread to the rest of Europe, where it was variously called Jugendstil in Germany, Modernismo in Spain, Stile Liberty in Italy, and École de Nancy in France. In architecture, Art Nouveau was both a philosophy and a style. Key characteristics include asymmetrical shapes, extensive use of arches and curved forms, decorative surfaces with curved lines, and the use of modern materials such as iron and glass. Nature was the principal source of inspiration for Art Nouveau artists, who found beauty in the organic rhythms and patterns of the natural world.

Notable Art Nouveau architects include Victor Horta, whose Hôtel Tassel in Brussels is considered the first true Art Nouveau building. Hector Guimard designed the iconic Paris Métro entrances. Antoni Gaudí created extraordinary structures in Barcelona, including the Sagrada Família and Casa Batlló. The style emphasized craftsmanship and believed that all arts should work in harmony. Architects designed not just buildings but every detail of the interior, including furniture, lighting, metalwork, and ceramics. This holistic approach created unified artistic environments. Art Nouveau's flowing lines and organic forms were revolutionary for their time. Buildings seemed to grow from the ground like living organisms. Façades featured undulating balconies, floral motifs in ironwork, and stained glass windows with natural themes.

The movement declined after 1910, partly due to its association with luxury and expense at a time when more austere styles were emerging. The outbreak of World War I essentially ended the Art Nouveau period, though its influence persisted in subsequent movements. Today, Art Nouveau architecture is highly valued and protected. UNESCO has designated several Art Nouveau buildings as World Heritage Sites, recognizing their cultural significance and unique contribution to architectural history.